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Neighborhood Transformation in East Asian Cities: Rethinking Gentrification and Global Capitalism

Introduction to the Special Issue on "Neighborhood Transformation in East Asian Cities: Rethinking Gentrification and Global Capitalism"

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1 | Background and Objective of the Special Issue

Gentrification is the process by which urban neighborhoods, usually home to low- and lower-middle-income residents, become the focus of reinvestment and settlement by middle-class inhabitants. This process is seen in the redevelopment and upgrading of residential and retail landscapes. Socially, gentrification is frequently represented by the displacement of existing residents in response to rising rents and property taxes. While initially associated with the redevelopment of older buildings, the process now also includes "new-build" gentrification, in which neighborhoods are razed and replaced with new buildings constructed from scratch (Jonas et al. 2015).

The rapid process of urbanization places East Asian megacities at the center of gentrification research and policy. Whether it is a skyscraper designed to draw global attention or a new tourist area that emphasizes cultural heritage, policymakers in cities across Asia are eager to make "nowhere" suddenly appear "somewhere." Yet, in terms of scale, speed, and the stakeholders involved, gentrification in Asian cities looks entirely different from the process of urban renewal in cities in Europe and the United States, where the term *gentrification* was first coined in the 1960s by Ruth Glass.

In the case of non-Western cities, scholars consider gentrification as part of a broader political and economic process that entails the unequal and uneven production of urban space, power struggles between communities of different socioeconomic levels, disputes over the upgrading of small neighborhoods, or more significant clashes resulting from social displacement experienced at the metropolitan or even regional scale (Shin and López-Morales 2018). Gentrification's blurred conceptual boundaries and its overlap with existing concepts indicate deficiencies in the rigor of the construct itself. Some scholars insist that displacement is a defining feature of gentrification (Elliott-Cooper et al. 2020), while others argue that the concept has been overdeveloped (Tang 2017) or is in a state of chaos (Kornatowski 2020).

The concept of gentrification also faces challenges of geographical referencing. In China, scholars have adopted the literal meaning of gentrifying (*shen shi hua*, 绅士化), while in Korea, analysts have emphasized the meaning of "forcing out" (*dungji naemolim*, 둥지 내몰림). In Japan, scholars use the term katakana (*jentorifikēshon*, ジェントリフィケーション), which is a simple transcription of gentrification. The concept of gentrification is difficult to translate into linguistic and cultural frameworks that are distant from English (Waley 2016). However, scholars worldwide continue to use the concept, represented in hegemonic theories written in English and propagated by academics in the West.

In China, the term "gentrification"—a concept directly translated from English—has gradually evolved into a relatively neutral or even positive term after entering the Chinese lexicon. It is often conflated with the terms "urban regeneration,"

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"urban renaissance," "urban renewal," and other similar concepts, weakening or even abandoning its original criticality. Alternatively, gentrification is regarded as a practical path to promote urban development, rural revitalization, and cultural tourism. In many cases, gentrification is interpreted as the refinement of space and residential elitism (Zhang and Ye 2022).

Compared with China, the gentrification debate in Japan has a longer and more in-depth history. Scholars identify four actors in the gentrification process: the state, the market, the third sector, and informal communities. Depending on which actor takes the initiative, gentrification can be categorized into four distinct types (Mizuuchi et al. 2019). Uchida (2015) argues that attention should be paid to the actors and to the degree of destination culture (目的地文化) associated with gentrification. Nevertheless, as used by researchers and some professionals, the concept of gentrification is not well known in Japanese society, as attested to by the following episode. In 2020, Taro Yamamoto, a member of the House of Councilors, asked if the government was aware of gentrification, which is a problem in major cities around the world. Former Prime Minister Shinzo Abe responded that it was difficult to answer because the main point was unclear.

To make a perfect kimono, artisans choose a *kujira jaku* (Japanese ruler) instead of a Western ruler because there is always a fraction that requires rounding up or down when using a Western ruler (Nakane 1967). Adopting Nakane's example as an analogy to contemporary urban studies, the driving questions of this special issue are as follows:

1. Is "gentrification" the best point of reference to describe the urban development in Asian cities?
2. Do we need alternative or additional frameworks, such as non-Western approaches, to understand the Asian context at the neighborhood level?
3. Are Asian cities and regions subject to the global homogenization of globalization and neoliberalism?

Expanding on the above questions, the goals of this special issue are (1) to understand the urban and geopolitical landscape of gentrification under global capitalism at the neighborhood level in East Asia, and (2) to identify more appropriate terms and lenses for capturing and analyzing the transformations of Asian cities by using locally specific languages and frameworks.

2 | Articles in This Special Issue

All articles in this special issue were selected from the conference papers "Neighborhood Transformation in East Asian Cities: Is 'Gentrification' the Right Frame of Reference?" held in Chiba, Japan, on May 15–17, 2022. Several thought-provoking papers addressing gentrification in the Japanese context were presented. In light of this journal's emphasis on developing countries, we have curated a diverse selection of research papers authored by scholars trained in both Eastern and Western academic traditions, with the aim of highlighting recent scholarship on gentrification in the context of East Asia's developing economies.

Ping (2026) analyzes urban transformation in post-reform Shanghai through the lens of the gentrification of middle-class taste and lifestyle. As Shanghai becomes an Instagrammable city amid the rise of social media, the new middle class actively engages in spatial consumption and social distinction. This process unfolds through state-led demolition and housing redevelopment, erasing collective memories while propagating a middle-class, moderately prosperous (*xiaokang*, 小康) society and the "Chinese Dream." Vernacular alleyway houses and Western-style villas are rebranded as popular social media check-in spots (*wanghong daka*, 网红打卡, literally, "registering one's presence on social media"), such as Xintiandi, Zhangyuan, Prada Rong Zhai, and Sinan Mansions. The study contends that *wanghong daka* culture promotes a surface-oriented urban aesthetic that accentuates class-based spatial restratification, thereby contributing to Shanghai's transformation into a city that is visually alluring yet increasingly detached from its lived experiences and sociocultural habitus.

Bonato (2026) analyzes green gentrification in Chongqing's Yubei and Liangjiang New Area (LJNA) within the context of state-led urbanization, eco-civilization discourse, and global capital restructuring. It highlights localized processes that challenge Western-centric gentrification frameworks. Online real estate platforms and political narratives promote the ethical commodification and privatization of green and water spaces, branding LJNA as an "eco-city" and "smart city." While upscale housing targets affluent classes, public rental units for migrants and low-income groups are built on the periphery, reinforcing spatial fragmentation and unequal access to resources. The study reveals how environmentalism, framed as an ethical practice, masks class inequality and calls for decolonial approaches and place-based knowledge in understanding urban transformation.

Sham (2026) critiques the assumed linkage between culture-led urban regeneration and gentrification. Using two cases in Taiwan—Twatutia (Taipei) and West Central District (Tainan)—it argues that such framing can obscure real urban challenges. Rising rents mainly affect newly arrived cultural businesses, rather than long-term residents, who are often protected by property ownership and social networks. The paper also highlights "touristification" caused by unregulated vendors and game machines, which has led to deteriorating living conditions—issues that fall outside classic gentrification narratives. It concludes that urban problems like rent pressure and disruption should be addressed separately from class-based displacement, allowing for more inclusive and sustainable regeneration.

Križnik and Kim (2026) examine the evolving scope of gentrification in Seoul through two cases: Sangwangsimni and Changsin-Sungin. While the former underwent state-led redevelopment resulting in direct displacement, the latter followed a participatory urban regeneration model aimed at inclusion. However, even in Changsin-Sungin, indirect displacement occurred through the loss of identity, weakening of community ties, and functional changes in the local economy. The study argues that gentrification in Seoul now extends beyond physical displacement to include cultural and symbolic exclusion. Despite inclusive rhetoric, urban regeneration often aligns with middle-class preferences and growth-driven agendas. The paper contributes to broader debates on state-led gentrification, emphasizing

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the ambivalent outcomes of participatory planning and the need for context-sensitive analyses in East Asian urbanism.

Endo (2026) examines urban transformation and the spatial exclusion of the urban poor in Bangkok through the lenses of gentrification, displacement, and urban informality. Amid Bangkok's rapid development, a real estate–driven urban agenda and global city ambitions have intensified pressures on low-income communities. The paper investigates the mechanisms behind this shift, the roles of key actors such as domestic conglomerates and foreign investors, and the impacts on affected residents. It identifies various forms of gentrification: heritage-led regeneration, transit-oriented development, and environmental gentrification. These processes often reflect government policies that prioritize elite interests, leading to spatial constraints, increased density, and forced relocations that fracture long-standing community networks. It critiques the dominant focus on iconic cases in existing research and underscores the overlooked erasure of ordinary neighborhoods. The study calls for inclusive, sustainable urban development beyond growth-centered paradigms.

Golik (2026) examines urban transformation in Ulaanbaatar's post-nomadic *ger* districts, showing that Western-style gentrification is not the dominant dynamic. Amid reduced state intervention, urban change follows diverse, locally rooted trajectories. While real estate investment is visible, change is also driven by resident agency and does not always involve class replacement. Infrastructure improvements can benefit low-income groups, and *ger* areas function as mixed-income spaces rather than slums. The success of development often hinges on bottom-up collaboration involving NGOs, international agencies, and communities. Gentrification is only one possible outcome within a complex landscape shaped by local dynamics and socio-spatial diversity.

3 | Findings: Presence of the State and Instagrammable Gentrification

The six papers collected in this special issue approach the topic of gentrification from diverse perspectives. Collectively, they demonstrate that the state plays a crucial role in shaping gentrification processes across East Asia.

Ping (2026) provides a comprehensive examination of the role of *wanghong daka* in the age of social media. She argues that within the broader timeline of rapid spatial transformation, Shanghai represents a particularly distinctive case. While large-scale displacement has occurred, both the state and capital have placed greater emphasis on producing an "internet-famous" cityscape that repackages and marketizes urban space, thereby obscuring the social suffering of ordinary people affected by massive forced demolition and relocation (*chaiqian*) over the past three decades.

In the case of Chongqing (Bonato 2026), the local government has built a new, modern city while securing substantial financial returns through land transfers. In the course of rapid urbanization, concepts such as green space, greenery, and waterscapes have emerged as shared discourses embraced across different social strata, thereby facilitating land expropriation and demolition. Within official narratives, the intensive and efficient utilization of land, water, and other natural resources is framed as contributing to sustainable development to be achieved through "smart" governance—that is, state-led management.

Sham (2026) contends that forms of urban renewal driven by the cultural industries should be excluded from the scope of gentrification. Although such processes may superficially resemble gentrification, they rarely involve displacement or significant changes in social stratification. He argues that culture-led urban renewal—together with the influx of tourists it attracts—deteriorates living environments but should not be conflated with gentrification. He highlights problems caused by excessive tourism, including the proliferation of arcade vendors, unregulated street stalls, and the worsening of public space conditions. To apply the concept of gentrification in this context, he cautions, would risk overlooking these pressing challenges of urban spatial governance. Sham further observes that while cafés may function as "eyes on the street" and contribute to neighborhood safety and order, arcade vendors cannot play such a role. His argument resonates with Nofre's (2020) claim that the deterioration of residential environments caused by tourism should not be equated with gentrification.

In the South Korean case, the city government also plays a pivotal role. Unlike the more heavy-handed approach of Chinese city governments, Seoul's administration, while leading the development of new districts, has also recognized the limitations of a fully state-driven model and thus began emphasizing urban regeneration. What distinguishes this model from traditional government-led approaches is its guarantee that local residents can participate in urban renewal projects, thereby ensuring that a wider range of social interests are considered and protected. Even so, under the pressure of commercialization, capital investment, and tourism, original residents continue to experience profound changes and feelings of dislocation.

In Bangkok, the city government aspires to transform the city into a cosmopolitan hub while facing the challenge of accommodating its lower socioeconomic strata. The interaction between state and society has given rise to gentrification processes of varying forms. A key issue concerns how to address "informality," which directly affects both the pace and trajectory of urbanization. In Chongqing, for instance, to prevent a large influx of farmers from becoming part of the urban informal population—or even homeless—the city government provided public housing for rural migrants. However, these units were built in less desirable areas. This practice became known as the "Chongqing model" of urbanization and was subsequently adopted by many other Chinese cities (Lafarguette 2011). By contrast, in Bangkok, the city government has been unable to provide sufficient public housing, leaving public opposition unresolved.

Not all city governments take an active role in urbanization. A particularly striking case is Ulaanbaatar. During the communist period, Mongolia pursued a state-led policy that forced nomadic populations into permanent settlement. For nomads whose livelihoods depended on free mobility, this experience was profoundly traumatic. In the post-socialist era, shaped by reflection on and reaction against the coercive power of the state, the Ulaanbaatar city government has been far less active in addressing social issues.

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In the case of Bangkok, Endo (2026) draws repeatedly on Shin's concept of the "displacement clock" (Shin 2018). The study focuses on the displacement of lower social strata, a process frequently accompanied by anxiety and distress. By contrast, in Seoul's regeneration projects, residents in tourist-concentrated areas—though not physically displaced—experience another form of unease arising from capital-driven transformations of community spaces and the influx of large numbers of tourists. Meanwhile, in China, numerous stories circulate about individuals who have become suddenly wealthy through demolition compensation. For these groups, the moment of demolition is often experienced with excitement and anticipation rather than the sorrow of displacement. This sense of "excitement" resonates with the glamorous and polished spatial outcomes that gentrification ultimately produces.

The Shanghai case highlights the notion of *wanghong* (internet-fame) or "Instagrammability" as a useful lens of observation. Researchers, much like the general public, are often drawn to what is visually striking, attractive, and novel. At the 2022 conference on gentrification, an interesting pattern emerged: many scholars, independently of one another, shared photographs of cafés that had appeared within their research sites. The presence of cafés in relatively declining neighborhoods was indeed eye-catching, and as "eyes on the street," they were often evaluated positively. Yet cafés alone cannot account for the broader social transformations unfolding in urban spaces. Endo (2026) offers a serious critique of the overextended use of the gentrification concept, warning against an exclusive focus on visually appealing urban spectacles and treating them as paradigmatic, while overlooking the displaced majority. In this sense, scholars, too, may sometimes behave like consumers of internet-famous trends, following what is fresh and fashionable—an inclination that is not necessarily negative, but requires critical reflection.

Finally, it is worth returning to the central theme of the 2022 conference: Is the concept of gentrification appropriate for analyzing Asian cities? Several contributors raised strong critiques and offered new refinements and reinterpretations of the concept, yet none dismissed it altogether. In our view, the concept of gentrification remains in the process of localization within Asian urban studies. To borrow Nakane's metaphor, this resembles the shift "from the Western ruler to the Japanese ruler"—a process of adjusting for excesses, shortcomings, and contextual differences that requires continued collective engagement among scholars. One of the strengths of the gentrification concept lies in its capacity to provide a common platform through which researchers from diverse regions can engage in dialogue, reflect on their respective cases, and generate mutual insights. We must also acknowledge that neither a single international conference nor one special issue can resolve all conceptual challenges. The critical exploration and refinement of gentrification within Asian contexts remains an ongoing task for future scholarly inquiry.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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